

Gordon LA-EN

Controversiarum Epitome — the reception principle and the sole acknowledged successor (*Excerpta*)

by James Gordon Huntly, S.J. (1541–1620), Scot; *Controversiarum Epitome*, Cologne 1620

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- *Latin transcribed complete (no elisions) from the page images of the Cologne 1620 edition (MDZ bsb10773915), Controversia II (De Ecclesia): the De Oecumenicis Conciliis chapter §§IX–XVI (printed pp. 259–260) and the De Summo Pontifice sections §§XII–XIII, XVI (pp. 233–234) with the objections §§IX, XV (pp. 245, 247). Long-s normalized, tildes/-que expanded silently, original spelling retained; marginal citations bracketed. A numbering correction against earlier research notes: the supreme-judgment clause belongs to §XII (the Quintum), not §XIII — verified by catchword.*
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- *Selection pages: printed pp. 233–234, 245, 247, 259–260*

Note on this selection: Bellarmine’s acceptance-doctrine as it reached the classroom — a one-volume epitome of the Controversies by the Scottish Jesuit James Gordon of Huntly, printed the year of his death. Three load-bearing moments. (1) The reception principle, stated as a rule against private judgment: to the Protestant claim that the later councils were illegitimate for want of due form, “it is not for any private man to judge of this matter, but for the whole Church: and since she has received all these councils as legitimate for so many years, we must not now call them into doubt” — the same principle Cyprian (0251), Bernard (1132), and Passerinus (1670) apply to the papal title, here guarding the conciliar canon. (2) The providence argument in epitome form: the adversaries themselves concede no better remedy against heresies exists; “either this will be the certain remedy, or there will plainly be none — which is to deny divine Providence and God’s love toward his Church.” (3) On the papal side, the argument from sole acknowledgment: “no other successor of Blessed Peter than the Roman Pontiff has ever hitherto been acknowledged in the Church of Christ” — universal recognition as the public warrant of the succession, with Leo’s dictum that Peter’s “dignity does not fail even in an unworthy heir.” The two objection-answers complete the armory: Peter’s fault

at Antioch was “of conduct, not of preaching” (Tertullian), and the wicked-popes argument is “the Donatists’ argument,” refuted by Augustine — and by Calvin himself against the Anabaptists (“for Calvin well knew that among his own Ministers not a few were wicked”). Classification: School 1 (note unassigned); the entry also documents the conditions-taxonomy (§§IX–XI: illegitimate assembly or procedure, and the necessity of papal approbation — Trent seeking Pius IV’s confirmation, the same datum Erbermann’s acceptance-syllogism uses).

Controversia II — selected sections

<i>Latin (1620)</i>	<i>English</i>
§ IX — Tertium: the illegitimacy taxonomy. Tertium est. Agnoscimus illa Concilia errare posse, quæ vel non legitimè sunt congregata, vel	

non legitimè procedunt. Nam talia re vera non congregantur in nomine Christi; cuiusmodi fuerunt, Ariminense Arrianorum: Ephesinum 2. Eutychianorum: Constantinopolitanum septimum Iconoclastarum: quæ proinde frustra nobis obijciunt aduersarij. || **§ IX — Tertium: the illegitimacy taxonomy.** The third is: We acknowledge that those Councils can err which either are not legitimately assembled, or do not legitimately proceed. For such are not truly gathered in the name of Christ; of which sort were the Ariminum council of the Arians, the second Ephesine of the Eutychians, the seventh of Constantinople of the Iconoclasts: which our adversaries therefore object against us in vain. || **§ X — Quartum: papal approbation required.** Quartum est. Etiam si Concilium legitimè congregatum, & rectè videatur procedere: nihilominus definitiones illius certæ omnino non erunt, secundum multorum Catholicorum sententiam; nisi his accedat etiam approbatio Summi Pontificis Romani, si ipse non adsit Concilio. [marg.: Vide Bell. l. 2. de Eccl. militante c. 11.] || **§ X — Quartum: papal approbation required.** The fourth is: Even if a Council be legitimately assembled and seem to proceed rightly, nevertheless its definitions will not be altogether certain, according to the opinion of many Catholics, unless there be added to them the approbation of the Supreme Roman Pontiff, if he himself is not present at the Council. [marg.: See Bellarmine, bk. 2 De Ecclesia militante, ch. 11.] || **§ XI — Ratio: the imperfect body without its visible Head.** Ratio est, quia antequam Concilium approbetur à Summo Pontifice, illud adhuc est imperfectum corpus Christi, sine Capite visibili: Et tale Corpus titubare, & cadere potest. Atque hinc est, quòd Concilium Tridentinum petierit confirmationem Pij IV. qui & illud postea solemniter approbauit. Id quod petierunt quoque alia antiqua Concilia: illa etiam quæ recipiunt aduersarij, verbi gratia, Nicænum primum, Chalcedonense, sexta synodus; vt alia posteriora Concilia omittamus. [marg.: Concil. Trid. sess. vlt. in fine. Conc. Nicæn. 1. de quo Bar. tom. 3. an. 325. num. 171. Chalcedonense actione 3. in fine, in Ep. ad S. Leon. Papam. Sexta synodus in Epist. ad Agathonem Ap.] || **§ XI — Ratio: the imperfect body without its visible Head.** The reason is: because before a Council is approved by the Supreme Pontiff, it is still an imperfect body of Christ, without its visible Head; and such a body can totter and fall. And hence it is that the Council of Trent sought the confirmation of Pius IV, who afterwards also solemnly approved it. Which other ancient Councils likewise sought — even those which the adversaries receive, for example the first of Nicaea, Chalcedon, the sixth synod; to say nothing of other later Councils. [marg.: Council of Trent, last session, at the end; Nicaea I (Baronius, vol. 3, an. 325, n. 171); Chalcedon, act 3, at the end, in the letter to St. Leo the Pope; the sixth synod in the letter

to Agatho.] || **§ XII — Quintum: the approved synod cannot err (the supreme-judgment ratio).** Quintum est. Asserimus Synodum Oecumenicam approbatam à Romano Pontifice, non posse errare in fide. Ratio est, quia necesse est aliquod iudicium supremum in Ecclesia Dei, cui omnes debent se submittere fidemque indubitatum in rebus controuersis adhibere: vt suprâ probatum est. Sed aliud iudicium supremum ab isto esse non potest. [marg.: Suprà c. 17. huius Controuersiae.] || **§ XII — Quintum: the approved synod cannot err (the supreme-judgment ratio).** The fifth is: We assert that an Ecumenical Synod approved by the Roman Pontiff cannot err in faith. The reason is: because there must be some supreme judgment in the Church of God, to which all are bound to submit themselves and to give undoubting faith in controverted matters, as was proved above; and there can be no supreme judgment other than this one. [marg.: Above, ch. 17 of this Controversy.] || **§ XIII — the historical argument.** Deinde videmus à principio Ecclesiæ huc vsque omnes hæreses, & controuersias de fidei dogmatibus sublata fuisse per Concilia generalia: Quare qui hoc negant, viam aperiunt omnibus antiquis hæresibus. Quod cùm experientia didicissent aduersarij in Antitrinitarijs, Anabaptistis, Vbiquitarijs, & alijs similibus, coacti fuerunt recipere sex illa antiquiora Concilia, vt dictum est: sed omnium legitimorum Conciliorum generalium par est, & æqualis autoritas. || **§ XIII — the historical argument.** Further, we see that from the beginning of the Church down to the present, all heresies and controversies about the dogmas of the faith have been removed through general Councils. Wherefore those who deny this open the way to all the old heresies. And since the adversaries learned this by experience with the Antitrinitarians, the Anabaptists, the Ubiquitarians, and other such, they were compelled to receive those six more ancient Councils, as has been said: but the authority of all legitimate general Councils is equal and the same. || **§ XIV — the providence argument.** Denique ipsi aduersarij agnoscunt, nullum esse melius aut certius remedium ad tollendas hæreses: erit ergo hoc certum remedium, vel nullum plane erit: quod est negare diuinam Prouidentiam & amorem erga suam Ecclesiam. [marg.: Calvin. l. 4. inst. c. 9. sect. 13.] || **§ XIV — the providence argument.** Finally, the adversaries themselves acknowledge that there is no better or more certain remedy for removing heresies. Either, then, this will be the certain remedy, or there will plainly be none — which is to deny divine Providence and God's love toward his Church. [marg.: Calvin, bk. 4 Inst., ch. 9, sect. 13.] || **§ XV — the reception principle.** Porrò, quòd dicunt aduersarij, posteriora Concilia non esse legitima, quia non seruauerunt debitum modum, & formam; Id plane falsum est. In primis, quia non est cuiusuis priuati hominis de hac re iudicare, sed totius Ecclesiæ: quæ cùm hæc omnia concilia, vt legitima à tot annis receperit, non debemus iam illa in dubium reuocare. || **§ XV — the reception principle.** Moreover, as to the adversaries' claim that the later Councils are not legitimate because they did not observe the due mode and form: this is plainly false. In the first place, because it is not for any private man to judge of this matter, but for the whole Church: and since she has received all these councils as legitimate for so many years, we must not now call them into doubt. || **§ XVI — the form of synods (continuation).** Deinde cùm aduersarij recipiant sex prima concilia, ex his petenda erit legitima forma Synodorum; quæ eadem plane est cum illa, quæ in posterioribus est obseruata: vt in singulis illis sex primis Synodis euidenter ostendit Baronius per singulas ætates. [Continues into a discussion of Calvin; ends on PDF p. 277. Included here only because it is the immediate continuation of § XV's reception argument; not among the passages requested.] || **§ XVI — the form of synods (continuation).** Further, since the adversaries receive the first six councils, the legitimate form of Synods must be sought from these; and it is plainly the same as that which has been observed in the later ones, as Baronius evidently shows for each of those first six Synods through the several ages. [Continues into a discussion of Calvin.] || **§ XVII — the keys remain, "as all acknowledge".** Deinde, Claues istæ manent semper in Ecclesia, vt omnes agnoscunt, ergo & ille cui claues sunt datæ. Similiter potestas ligandi & soluendi semper manet in Ecclesia. Neque enim data est ista potestas, aut datæ sunt claues illæ, propter B. Petrum solùm, sed propter Ecclesiam, quæ

semper manet. Ecclesia igitur & Claves, & potestatem ligandi atque soluendi semper retinet in Petro, & eius successoribus. || **§ XII — the keys remain, “as all acknowledge”.** Further, those Keys remain always in the Church, as all acknowledge; therefore so does he to whom the keys were given. Likewise the power of binding and loosing always remains in the Church. For that power was not given, nor were those keys given, for the sake of Blessed Peter alone, but for the sake of the Church, which remains always. The Church therefore always retains both the Keys and the power of binding and loosing, in Peter and his successors. || **§ XIII — the sole acknowledged successor; dignity undiminished in an unworthy heir.** Atque hoc est quod dicit S. Leo cùm scribit, B. Petrum in hodiernum vsque diem Ecclesiam gubernare (videlicet per suos successores) idque adeò, vt eius dignitas in indigno etiam hærede non deficiat. Porrò, alius successor B. Petri, quàm Romanus Pontifex nunquam hactenus agnitus est in Ecclesia Christi: est igitur Romanus Pontifex B. Petri successor, & supremus Ecclesiæ Episcopus: estque Romana Ecclesia non tantùm vera Christi Ecclesia, sed & cæteris omnibus ab ipso Christo prælata. [marg.: S. Leo serm. 2. in anniuersario assumptionis suæ ad Pontificatum.] || **§ XIII — the sole acknowledged successor; dignity undiminished in an unworthy heir.** And this is what St. Leo says when he writes that Blessed Peter governs the Church even to the present day (namely through his successors), and that so truly that his dignity does not fail even in an unworthy heir. Moreover, no other successor of Blessed Peter than the Roman Pontiff has ever hitherto been acknowledged in the Church of Christ: therefore the Roman Pontiff is Blessed Peter’s successor and the supreme Bishop of the Church; and the Roman Church is not only the true Church of Christ, but also set by Christ himself over all the others. [marg.: St. Leo, sermon 2 on the anniversary of his elevation to the Pontificate.] || **§ XVI — the pastoral office perpetual.** Denique constat hanc promissionem Christi non spectare ad solam personam B. Petri, sed etiam ad successores eius, qui perpetuò in Ecclesia remansuri erant. Nam officium Pastoris ordinarium esse, atque perpetuò in Ecclesia permanere, & Apostolus apertè testatur, & agnoscunt nostri aduersarij. [marg.: Eph. 4. v. 11. Calvin. & Beza ibid. Conf. Rupell. art. 25.] || **§ XVI — the pastoral office perpetual.** Finally, it is evident that this promise of Christ does not regard the person of Blessed Peter alone, but also his successors, who were to remain perpetually in the Church. For that the office of Pastor is ordinary, and remains perpetually in the Church, both the Apostle openly testifies, and our adversaries acknowledge. [marg.: Eph. 4:11; Calvin and Beza there; the Confession of La Rochelle, art. 25.] || **§ IX — Peter rebuked: conduct, not preaching.** Tertium argumentum. Etiam post datam illam potestatem, Ioan. 21. Petrus fuit reprehensus à S. Paulo Gal. 2. Respondeo: Illud ipsum olim obiecerunt Marcionistæ Catholicis, teste Tertulliano: quibus respondet Tertullianus alio in loco his verbis: Vtique (inquit) conuersationis fuit vitium, non prædicationis. Et rectè respondet Tertullianus: nam poterat fortè S. Petrus tunc peccasse, sed in fide errare non poterat, quia bene sciebat, legem Mosaicam non esse necessariam Gentibus ad salutem, neque vnquam docuit, illam esse necessariam: Imò quando de hac re controuersia orta fuit, ipse apertè docuit eam non obligare Gentes, vt in actibus Apostolorum videre licet. Quare si qua in re peccauit sanctus Petrus, conuersationis fuit peccatum, non autem doctrinæ, aut prædicationis: de quo solo nos hic disputamus. [marg.: Tertull. li. 5. adu. Marcionem, c. 3. Tertull. de præscr. adu. hæc. c. 4[?].23. in fine. Actor 15. v. 10. & 11.] || **§ IX — Peter rebuked: conduct, not preaching.** Third argument. Even after that power was given (John 21), Peter was rebuked by St. Paul (Gal. 2). I reply: The Marcionites of old objected this very thing to the Catholics, as Tertullian testifies; to whom Tertullian replies elsewhere in these words: ‘It was,’ he says, ‘a fault of conduct, not of preaching.’ And Tertullian answers rightly: for St. Peter could perhaps have sinned then, but he could not err in faith, because he well knew that the Mosaic law was not necessary to the Gentiles for salvation, nor did he ever teach that it was necessary: nay, when controversy arose on this matter, he himself openly taught that it did not bind the Gentiles, as may be seen in the Acts of the Apostles. Wherefore if St. Peter sinned in anything, it was a sin of conduct, not of

doctrine or preaching — which alone is what we are disputing about here. [marg.: Tertullian, bk. 5 against Marcion, ch. 3; Tertullian, De praescriptione adv. haer., at the end; Acts 15:10-11.] || § **XV — wicked popes: the Donatist fallacy.** Sextum argumentum. Multi ex Romanis pontificibus fuerunt impij, & varijs peccatis addicti, vt testantur omnes Scriptores, etiam Catholici: igitur sicut illi in moribus grauiter errarunt, ita poterant & in doctrina errare. Respondeo: Illud ipsum olim fuerat argumentum Donatistarum contra Catholicos, cui sæpè respondit S. Augustinus. Dispar namque est ratio conuersationis, & doctrinæ: quia error in conuersatione soli erranti nocet, sed error in doctrina nocet etiam alijs, imò toti Ecclesiæ. Hinc illa Christi admonitio: Omnia quæcumque dixerint vobis, seruare & facite: secundum opera verò eorum nolite facere. Imò Caluinus ipse hoc argumentum aduersariorum multis verbis refutat, tanquam Anabaptistarum inuentum: bene enim sciebat Caluinus, inter suos Ministros non paucos esse malos & impios. Quare mirum est quòd eius sectatores toties hoc argumentum repetant. [marg.: S. Aug. to. 2. ep. 165. ad Generosum, & to. 7. cont. liter. Petiliani Donatistæ, li. 2. c. 5. 6. 51. Mat. 23. v. 2. Caluin. li. 4. Inst. c. 1. sect. 13. & seqq.] || § **XV — wicked popes: the Donatist fallacy.** Sixth argument. Many of the Roman pontiffs were impious and given to various sins, as all writers, even Catholic ones, testify: therefore, just as they erred gravely in morals, so they could also err in doctrine. I reply: This very argument was of old the Donatists' argument against the Catholics, to which St. Augustine often replied. For the case of conduct and of doctrine is not the same: because an error in conduct harms only the one erring, but an error in doctrine harms others too — nay, the whole Church. Hence that admonition of Christ: 'All things whatsoever they shall say to you, observe and do: but according to their works do ye not.' Nay, Calvin himself refutes this argument of the adversaries at length, as an invention of the Anabaptists: for Calvin well knew that among his own Ministers not a few were wicked and impious. Wherefore it is a wonder that his followers so often repeat this argument. [marg.: St. Augustine, vol. 2, ep. 165 to Generosus, and vol. 7 against the letters of Petilian the Donatist, bk. 2, chs. 5, 6, 51; Matt. 23:2; Calvin, bk. 4 Inst., ch. 1, sect. 13 ff.] |